diplomat V. Venkateswara Rao, defence attaché Brig. Ravi Dutt Mehta, and ITBP personnel H. A. S. Pathania and Roop Singh. Shakoor had been tailing Mehta and Rao's car that morning and was intent on destroying the whole embassy.[36] Mehta, however, was the prized target. Within a mere six months, he had built a strong network of contacts with a variety of Afghan political, military, and intelligence officials. Given that R&AW officers stationed in Kabul were being constantly watched, the military intelligence (MI) and the Defence Intelligence Agency (DIA) had become active in covert operations inside Afghanistan.[37] Military intelligence officers manned all Indian medical missions in Afghanistan and used them as cover to gather critical intelligence. Moreover, paying money to local power brokers to undertake its developmental projects, India (mostly through these officers) created effective information networks across the country. Khare asserts that the best intelligence in Afghanistan came from the MI, including on-the-ground information about what was actually happening. 'I never, in my five years of tenure [at the JIC] and in high level meeting with the deputy NSAs and NSAs, got any intel[ligence] from R&AW [on Afghanistan] till 2011', he says.[38] Mehta in particular was an officer who had set up a lot of networks in Afghanistan that threatened Pakistan. Khare's colleague, Patil, concurs that Indian military personnel in Afghanistan generated high quality intelligence, but asserts that most of it reached the JIC via R&AW.[39] Given that Indian military officers undergo secondment with R&AW, it is possible that both the MI (and/or DIA) and the R&AW were active on the ground. Either way, Indian military personnel were playing an important role in Afghanistan, and this fact did not go unnoticed by Pakistani agencies.

Supplementing India's activism in Afghanistan, the Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) launched an insurgency against Pakistan in 2007. Though supported by Pakistan's establishment in the first place, the TTP had turned its back on Pakistan after a series of failed ceasefires (the intent of which was seriously doubted by India). The situation in Balochistan had also taken a turn for the worse since 2004. In April 2006, Pakistan banned the Balochistan Liberation Army (BLA) that had been waging an alarmingly successful sabotage campaign against the battle-hardened Pakistan army for the past seventeen months. Occurring in the middle of an ongoing composite dialogue between India and